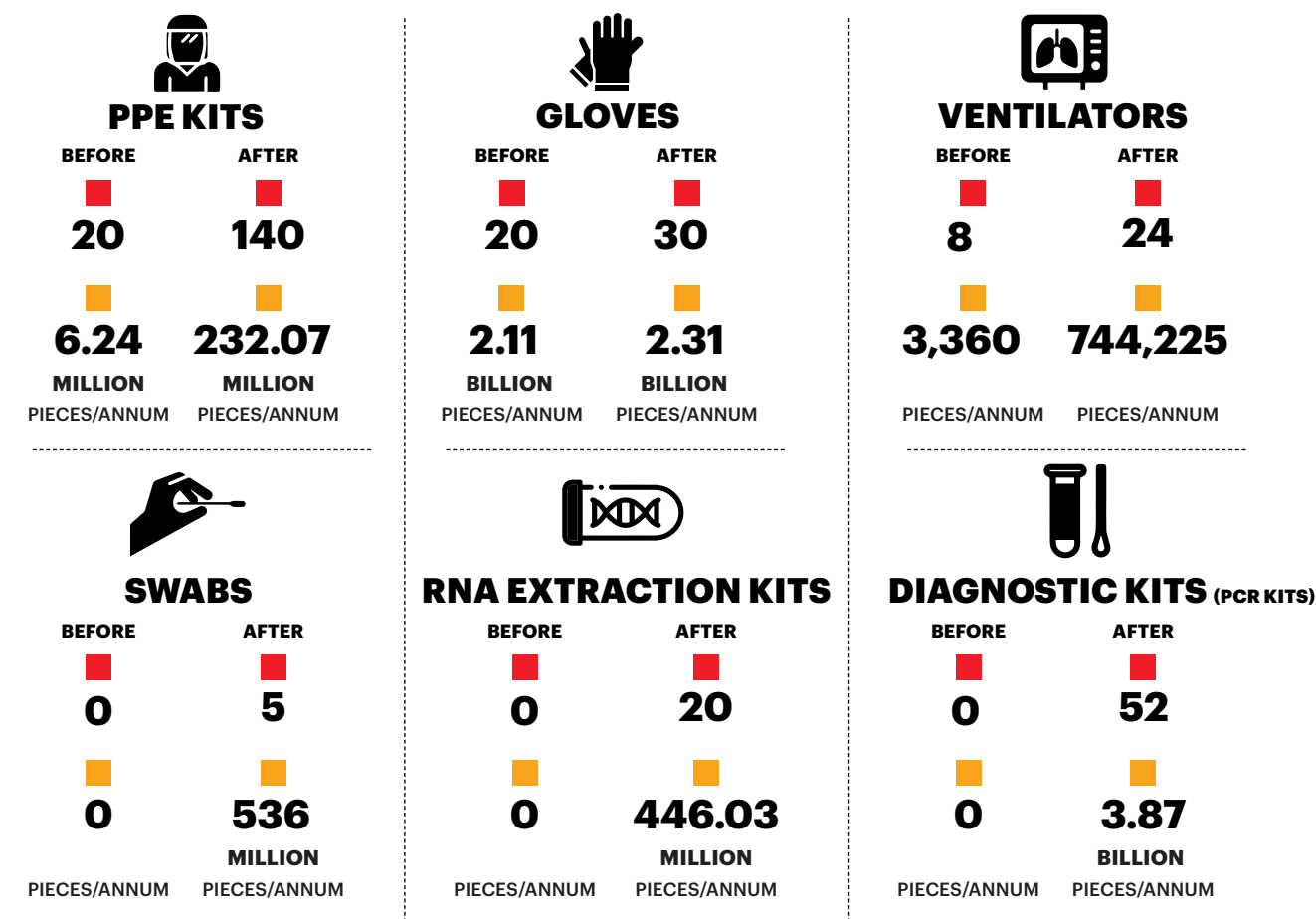


WORLDS APART

Makers of Covid-19 paraphernalia saw a huge jump in production since the pandemic began



GRAPHICS BY ANIRBAN GHOSH

3.3x to ₹558.95 crore in FY21 from ₹168.55 crore in FY20. Being an end-to-end hospital supplies and equipment procurement platform, the company saw a huge surge in Covid-19 protection and treatment-related products and equipment. “We sold close to 1,000 ventilators during Covid-19,” says Tiwari, adding that there have been no orders for ventilators in the past two quarters, while demand for oxygen concentrators was negligible. As for face shields, the company has seen no demand in the past few months.

SETTING OFF LOSSES

Industry experts say that with the pandemic showing signs of receding, the central government lifting provisions of the Disaster Management Act, and state governments easing restrictions, a large number of Covid-19-related supplies, equipment and accessories remain unutilised. Manufacturers are trying to repurpose their products to mitigate financial losses.

AiMeD’s Nath says that those manufacturers who were in existence prior to Covid-19, and were exporting these products “are relatively better off as they have a more sustainable supply chain to cater to”. But those who entered the medical device manufacturing space recently

as they saw it as a golden opportunity “are now facing liquidity challenges and scaling down production or shutting operations or selling off their machinery. We are encouraging them to seek QA Certification so that they can export surpluses.”

For instance, in the first wave of Covid-19, Max Ventilator, a manufacturer of medical ventilators and allied medical devices, achieved growth of 100 per cent and in 2021 saw business of ₹100 crore. But now, the company is looking at other products. “Many of those ventilators were Covid-19-specific machines which is why they have now lost their utility. And probably after the Covid-19 demand has saturated, there won’t be much demand for them. So, we have another three products that are meant for ICUs, but not necessarily for Covid-19, and that could result in 25 per cent growth for the company,”